MONTESSORI MAKERS GROUP

The Montessori *Equity Audit*

TOOLBOX EDITION

A self-guided diagnostic for Montessori leadership teams ready to look honestly at their own practice and translate what they learn into the work the school will actually take up.

FROM THE DESK OF

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WELCOME

What this audit is, and what it is not

Thank you for purchasing the Toolbox Edition of the Montessori Equity Audit. This document is built for school leadership teams that are ready to look honestly at their own practice and to translate what they learn into the work the school will actually take up.

This is a structured self-assessment for the leadership team across four domains of school life. It surfaces what is actually happening in the school, not what the school wishes were happening or what the school looks like from the outside. The questions are written to produce evidence, not affirmation. Schools that complete this audit honestly will find some of what they learn unwelcome. That is the point.

This audit is grounded in Montessori philosophy and in the practice of justice work. It assumes that respect for the child is a structural commitment, not a sentiment. It assumes that equity is not a program added to the side of the school but a property of how the school is organized, staffed, financed, and led. It assumes the leadership team is an adult community capable of holding hard truths about its own functioning.

A NOTE ON TONE

This is accountability work, not sensitivity training. The questions are written to produce useful information, not comfortable feelings. If the work feels challenging, that is not a sign you are doing it wrong. It is a sign you are doing it.

What this audit is

A diagnostic instrument across four domains. A self-scoring guide that helps your team interpret your results. A structured debrief protocol your team uses together to translate findings into priorities. A next steps section that names what schools can address internally and what typically requires outside support.

What this audit is not

This is not a public-facing equity statement. The diagnostic is a private working document for the leadership team. This is not a scoring rubric you turn in to a board, an accreditor, or a regulatory body. It is a tool the leadership team uses to surface honest information for itself. This is not a substitute for the consultant-led Advisory version. The Advisory version includes an outside facilitator who holds the room through the harder conversations the diagnostic produces. The Toolbox version assumes your team is capable of holding that room itself, and it will tell you honestly when you are not.

Who should be in the room

This audit is designed for school leadership teams of three to twelve people. The team should include the head of school or executive director, program directors across all levels the school serves, and senior staff who hold real decision-making authority. If your school has a board chair or board equity committee chair who is engaged with day-to-day school operations, include them. If your school has staff of color in lead roles who are not currently part of formal leadership but whose perspective is essential to this work, name that openly and invite them with appropriate role clarity and compensation for the additional time.

Do not run this audit with only the head of school and a single program director. The diagnostic depends on multiple perspectives surfacing different reads of the same school. A team of two will produce a thinner result than a team of six.

Do not run this audit with the entire faculty in the first pass. Faculty-wide use of the instrument is a separate project that requires different framing and different protections. Start with leadership. Earn the credibility to take this work to the rest of the school by demonstrating that leadership took it seriously first.

WHO SHOULD FACILITATE

Designate one team member to facilitate the debrief session. This person should not be the head of school. The facilitator's role is to hold the structure, slow the conversation when it speeds past disagreement, and bring the team back to evidence when the room moves toward impression.

How to create the conditions for honest engagement

Real equity work cannot happen in a room organized around protecting leadership from discomfort. Before you begin, the head of school needs to communicate three things to the team in writing or in conversation.

First, that honest answers will not result in punitive consequences. If a team member's diagnostic responses include critical observations of leadership decisions, those observations cannot become an evaluation issue or a scheduling consequence afterward. Second, that the team's purpose for the day is to look honestly, not to demonstrate that the school is doing well. Third, that the head of school will be quiet for portions of the conversation when others have a closer view of the question on the table.

If the head of school cannot make those three commitments, the audit will not produce useful results. That is also information. It tells you that the conditions for this work are not yet present and that the next step before the diagnostic is repair work inside leadership itself.

Plan for time. The diagnostic takes each member of the team approximately ninety minutes to complete independently across two sittings. The debrief session runs four hours, ideally split across two two-hour conversations on different days. Splitting the debrief lets the team sit with what surfaced before deciding what to act on. Same-day debriefs produce thinner priorities.

How to use this guide

STEP	WHAT TO DO
Step 1 Decide who is in the room	Identify your three to twelve person leadership team. Confirm the facilitator. Confirm the dates for the debrief session.
Step 2 Set the conditions	Communicate the three commitments. Block the time. Print or share the diagnostic instrument with each team member.
Step 3 Complete the diagnostic independently	Each member of the team completes the instrument alone, across two sittings, in approximately ninety minutes. Do not do this together.

STEP	WHAT TO DO
Step 4 Score and synthesize	The facilitator collects the responses and uses the self-scoring guide to identify domain averages, spread, and the highest-leverage questions for discussion.
Step 5 Run the debrief protocol	Work through the four-round debrief protocol over four hours, ideally split across two days. The protocol is structured to keep the conversation honest without an outside facilitator.
Step 6 Write your priorities	Translate what surfaced into a written priority list using the structure provided. Name owners. Name timelines. Name success indicators.
Step 7 Decide what is internal and what needs help	Use the next steps section to identify which priorities your school can carry internally and which typically require outside support to do honestly.

THE DIAGNOSTIC

The Diagnostic Instrument

Each member of the leadership team completes this instrument independently before the debrief session. Plan for ninety minutes of focused time across two sittings. Do not complete it in a meeting, and do not complete it together at this stage. Independent responses produce the divergence the team needs to do meaningful work in the debrief.

For each question, choose a response from one to four. The descriptors are intentionally brief because what matters more than the number is the evidence written in the notes field underneath. A score with no evidence is not data. A note that begins with the phrase we are working on it is also not data. In the notes field, write the specific examples, data points, names of practices, or absences that justify your rating.

THE RESPONSE SCALE

RATING	WHAT IT MEANS IN THIS AUDIT
1 Not yet	We have not addressed this. There is no shared language, no practice in place, and no one currently accountable.
2 Beginning	We have started a conversation or made a recent commitment. Practice is uneven across the school and depends on individual staff.
3 Developing	There is an emerging practice that some teams use consistently. It is documented in places but not yet a property of the whole school.
4 Established	This is how we operate. The practice is named, written, distributed, resourced, and held to account beyond any single person.

A TEST FOR ANY SCORE OF FOUR

If you score a four, be prepared to name where it is documented, who owns it, how the school responds when it is not happening, and what the consequence has been when accountability was needed. Otherwise the score is aspiration, not evidence.

DOMAIN

01

Hiring, Retention, and Workforce Equity

Who is hired, who is retained, who is paid what, and who advances. This domain examines whether your stated values are reflected in the actual people who keep your school running and in the conditions of their work.

01	Look at the racial and ethnic demographics of your full faculty over the past three years. Does the composition of your teaching team reflect the racial and ethnic diversity of the children and families you serve?		
1 Not yet	2 Beginning	3 Developing	4 Established
EVIDENCE AND NOTES			

02	Examine your starting salaries for lead guides at each program level. Could a Black, Indigenous, Latina, or Asian Montessori-trained guide afford to take this job without a second income, partner subsidy, or family support?		
1 Not yet	**2** Beginning	**3** Developing	**4** Established
EVIDENCE AND NOTES			

03	Track the staff who have left your school in the past five years. Have teachers of color exited at higher rates than white teachers, and have you actually investigated why or only speculated about it?		
1 Not yet	**2** Beginning	**3** Developing	**4** Established

EVIDENCE AND NOTES

04	Review your current pipeline of assistants moving toward Montessori training. Are you funding training equitably across race and class lines, or are training dollars concentrated among staff who already had access to capital?		
1 Not yet	**2** Beginning	**3** Developing	**4** Established

EVIDENCE AND NOTES

05	Examine your last three rounds of leadership hires. When a leadership seat opened, did you actively recruit candidates of color from outside your existing network, or did you default to who was already in the room?		
1 Not yet	**2** Beginning	**3** Developing	**4** Established
EVIDENCE AND NOTES			

06	Look at your hiring rubrics. Are your evaluation criteria for fit defined in writing and grounded in the work, or has fit become a euphemism for cultural sameness and comfort?		
1 Not yet	**2** Beginning	**3** Developing	**4** Established

EVIDENCE AND NOTES

07	Examine your compensation for assistants, kitchen staff, and operations staff. Are these team members paid a living wage in your local market, or does your school operate on the economic precarity of the people who keep it running?		
1 Not yet	**2** Beginning	**3** Developing	**4** Established

EVIDENCE AND NOTES

08	Review the past three years of exit interviews from staff of color. Did patterns surface that you have actually responded to with structural change, or did you log the feedback and move on?		
1 Not yet	**2** Beginning	**3** Developing	**4** Established
EVIDENCE AND NOTES			

09	Look at promotion and advancement over the past five years. Who has moved from assistant to guide, from guide to leadership, and from leadership to executive, and what does that pattern reveal about who your school invests in?		
1 Not yet	**2** Beginning	**3** Developing	**4** Established

EVIDENCE AND NOTES

DOMAIN

02

Adult Culture, Belonging, and Psychological Safety

How adults treat each other, how disagreement and conflict move through the building, and who feels safe to tell the truth. This domain examines whether your school is a place where the adults can do hard work together or only an environment where they can be polite.

01	When a staff member raises a concern about a colleague's behavior toward children or adults, what actually happens in the next 72 hours? Walk through a recent example honestly.		
1 Not yet	**2** Beginning	**3** Developing	**4** Established
EVIDENCE AND NOTES			

02	Look at the dynamics of your last three faculty meetings. Who spoke, who did not, who interrupted whom, and whose ideas were attributed to someone else after the fact?		
1 Not yet	**2** Beginning	**3** Developing	**4** Established
EVIDENCE AND NOTES			

03	Examine the social geography of your staff lounge, kitchen, and break spaces. Do staff of color, hourly staff, and operations staff sit, eat, and laugh alongside white salaried staff, or are there visible separations no one names?		
1 Not yet	**2** Beginning	**3** Developing	**4** Established

EVIDENCE AND NOTES

04	Review the conflicts between adults in your building over the past year. Were they actually resolved through accountability and repair, or were they smoothed over and left to fester underneath the surface of the school?

1 Not yet	**2** Beginning	**3** Developing	**4** Established

EVIDENCE AND NOTES

05	When a staff member of color names a racial dynamic at work, where does the room move? Does it move toward defending the person who was named, or toward listening and asking what would be useful?		
1 Not yet	**2** Beginning	**3** Developing	**4** Established
EVIDENCE AND NOTES			

06	Examine how disagreement with leadership functions in your school. Can a teacher publicly disagree with the head of school without a quiet cost to their evaluation, schedule, or standing?		
1 Not yet	**2** Beginning	**3** Developing	**4** Established

EVIDENCE AND NOTES

07	Look at who covers absences, who stays late, and who is asked to absorb the extra. Does the labor of holding the school together fall disproportionately on women, on people of color, or on assistants paid the least?

1 Not yet	**2** Beginning	**3** Developing	**4** Established

EVIDENCE AND NOTES

08	Review your adult learning calendar for the past two years. How often have white staff been asked to sit with discomfort about race, class, gender, or power, and how often have staff of color been asked to carry the educational labor of those conversations?		
1 Not yet	**2** Beginning	**3** Developing	**4** Established
EVIDENCE AND NOTES			

09	Examine your celebration and acknowledgment practices. Whose birthdays, milestones, losses, and life events get noticed by leadership, and whose pass without comment?

1 Not yet	2 Beginning	3 Developing	4 Established
EVIDENCE AND NOTES			

DOMAIN

03

Curriculum, Representation, and Student Experience

What children encounter on the shelves, in the materials, in the books, in the cultural and history work, and in the daily texture of being seen by adults. This domain examines whether your prepared environment honors every child it serves.

01

Walk your prepared environments slowly, room by room. Whose bodies, families, languages, and stories are visible on the shelves and walls, and whose are absent?

1 Not yet	2 Beginning	3 Developing	4 Established
EVIDENCE AND NOTES			

02	Examine your cultural curriculum across all program levels. Are non-European cultures presented with the depth and dignity Montessori intended, or are they reduced to crafts, food, and holidays during a single month?		
1 Not yet	**2** Beginning	**3** Developing	**4** Established
EVIDENCE AND NOTES			

03	Look at the people, places, and histories named in your nomenclature work, your timeline materials, and your science and geography curriculum. Who is centered as a knower and a maker, and who is rendered invisible?		
1 Not yet	**2** Beginning	**3** Developing	**4** Established

EVIDENCE AND NOTES

04	Review your discipline data disaggregated by race, gender, and disability status. Are children of color, boys, and children with IEPs more likely to be redirected, removed from the environment, or referred for outside evaluation?		
1 Not yet	**2** Beginning	**3** Developing	**4** Established

EVIDENCE AND NOTES

05	Examine your written observations and narrative reports. Are children of color described in deficit language, behavioral framing, or surveillance terms more often than white children?		
1 Not yet	**2** Beginning	**3** Developing	**4** Established
EVIDENCE AND NOTES			

06	Look at your literature collection across every level. What percentage of your books center children of color, queer families, disabled children, and working-class families as full protagonists rather than as objects of study or curiosity?

1 Not yet	2 Beginning	3 Developing	4 Established
EVIDENCE AND NOTES			

07	Review your grace and courtesy and conflict resolution work. Does it teach children to hold each other accountable across difference and harm, or does it teach them to be polite while ignoring what is actually happening in the room?		
1 Not yet	2 Beginning	3 Developing	4 Established
EVIDENCE AND NOTES			

08	Examine which children receive the most extended one-on-one time with the most experienced adults in your school. Is that time distributed equitably, or do certain children consistently receive less of you?		
1 Not yet	**2** Beginning	**3** Developing	**4** Established
EVIDENCE AND NOTES			

09	Look at your community events, parent education, and family gatherings. Are working-class, single-parent, immigrant, and non-English-speaking families actually present and participating, or are they on your roster but absent from your community?		
1 Not yet	**2** Beginning	**3** Developing	**4** Established
EVIDENCE AND NOTES			

10	Review what your school actually teaches children about Indigenous peoples, enslavement, colonization, migration, and resistance. Are these histories woven into your culture and history work with age-appropriate honesty, or are they avoided in favor of more comfortable material?			
	1 Not yet	2 Beginning	3 Developing	4 Established
	EVIDENCE AND NOTES			

DOMAIN

04

Governance, Accountability, and Organizational Commitment

How the school is governed, financed, and held to account beyond its own self-report. This domain examines whether your equity commitments are structural decisions backed by money and authority or aspirations preserved in mission language.

01	Look at your board of trustees, governing body, or ownership structure. Does its racial, economic, and lived-experience composition reflect the children and families your school serves, or does it reflect your donor base and founders' networks?		
1 Not yet	**2** Beginning	**3** Developing	**4** Established
EVIDENCE AND NOTES			

02	Examine your operating budget line by line. What percentage is allocated to equity-related work, including compensation parity, professional learning, family support, language access, and curriculum investment?		
1 Not yet	**2** Beginning	**3** Developing	**4** Established
EVIDENCE AND NOTES			

03	Review your strategic plan. Is racial and economic equity named as a measurable goal with named owners, deliverables, and timelines, or is it referenced in mission language without operational teeth?

1 Not yet	2 Beginning	3 Developing	4 Established
EVIDENCE AND NOTES			

04	Look at how decisions actually get made in your school. Who has voice and who has vote in decisions about hiring, curriculum, discipline, admissions, and budget?		
1 Not yet	2 Beginning	3 Developing	4 Established
EVIDENCE AND NOTES			

05	Examine your tuition, financial aid, and enrollment data. Is your school accessible to families across the economic spectrum your community contains, or is it functionally an enclave of affluence?		
1 Not yet	**2** Beginning	**3** Developing	**4** Established
EVIDENCE AND NOTES			

06	Review your communication with families. Are critical school decisions, policy changes, and conflict resolutions communicated in the languages families actually speak in your community, or only in English?		
1 Not yet	**2** Beginning	**3** Developing	**4** Established

EVIDENCE AND NOTES

07

Look at your last three head of school, executive director, or principal searches. Was the search committee racially and economically diverse, and did the finalist pool include serious candidates of color the search took seriously?

1 Not yet	2 Beginning	3 Developing	4 Established

EVIDENCE AND NOTES

08	Examine your incident response practices. When a racial harm occurs in your school, do you have a written protocol you actually follow, or does each incident get handled ad hoc by whoever is closest and willing?		
1 Not yet	**2** Beginning	**3** Developing	**4** Established
EVIDENCE AND NOTES			

09	Review your partnerships, vendors, and contracted services. Are you intentionally directing dollars toward Black-owned, Indigenous-owned, immigrant-owned, and women-of-color-owned businesses, or does that work fall apart at the procurement step?		
1 Not yet	**2** Beginning	**3** Developing	**4** Established
EVIDENCE AND NOTES			

10	Look at the structures of accountability around your equity commitments. To whom is your school accountable beyond your own self-report, and what consequence exists if you do not deliver?		
1 Not yet	**2** Beginning	**3** Developing	**4** Established
EVIDENCE AND NOTES			

READING YOUR RESULTS

Self-Scoring Guide

After every member of the leadership team has completed the instrument independently, the facilitator collects the responses and prepares a synthesis for the debrief session. This guide explains how to read what the scores are telling your team.

Step one. Calculate two numbers per domain

For each domain, calculate the team average, which is the average of every team member's responses to every question in that domain. Then calculate the spread, which is the difference between the highest and lowest individual scores anyone gave on any question in that domain.

The average tells you where your team thinks the school is. The spread tells you something more important, which is how aligned your leadership team is about the school's reality. Both numbers are needed. A team that is averaging at three but disagreeing widely is in a different situation than a team averaging at three with full alignment.

Step two. Read the average

DOMAIN AVERAGE	WHAT IT INDICATES AND WHAT TO DO WITH IT
1.0 to 1.9	Critical attention required. Your school does not yet have foundational practice in this domain. This domain belongs at the top of your priority list and requires resourced action within the current school year.

DOMAIN AVERAGE	WHAT IT INDICATES AND WHAT TO DO WITH IT
2.0 to 2.5	Active development needed. Practice exists in places but is fragile, person-dependent, and not yet structural. This domain requires near-term action over the next six to twelve months with named owners and budget.
2.6 to 3.2	Strengthen and codify. Your school is doing real work in this domain but has not yet made the practice durable. Focus on documentation, distribution of responsibility, and accountability beyond individual champions.
3.3 to 4.0	Sustain and verify. Confirm with disaggregated data and family or staff voice that the score reflects lived experience across the community, not only leadership perception. If verified, the work here is to protect what is in place during transitions and growth.

Step three. Read the spread

SPREAD WITHIN YOUR TEAM	WHAT IT SUGGESTS ABOUT YOUR LEADERSHIP ALIGNMENT
0 to 1 point	Your team has a shared read of this domain. Whether the score is high or low, you can move forward together with shared language.
1 to 2 points	There is some divergence. Spend time in the debrief naming what each person is seeing and what evidence each person is using.

SPREAD WITHIN YOUR TEAM	WHAT IT SUGGESTS ABOUT YOUR LEADERSHIP ALIGNMENT
2 to 3 points	Your team is meaningfully misaligned about your school's reality in this domain. Treat this as a signal worth slowing down for. Misalignment at this level usually points to information asymmetry or unspoken conflict.
3 points or more	Your team is looking at two different schools. This is a structural issue, not a scoring issue. Often it indicates that someone on the team is much closer to the lived experience of the work than the others are, or that one person holds a perspective the rest of the team has been organized to not hear.

Step four. Identify your highest-leverage questions

After looking at domain averages and spreads, identify three categories of questions that need direct attention in the debrief. The lowest scoring questions across the whole instrument. The questions with the largest spread, where team members disagreed most. The questions where multiple respondents marked one or two, which signal that more than one person on the leadership team sees a gap in the same place.

These three categories produce the priority list your team brings into the debrief. You do not need to discuss every question. You need to discuss the questions that are telling you the most about your school.

A REMINDER BEFORE YOU GO FURTHER

If your scores are evenly high across all four domains and your team is fully aligned, the most likely explanation is not that your school is exceptional. The most likely explanation is that the people closest to the harm are not the people taking this assessment. Consider whether your scoring reflects leadership perception or lived experience across your community.

THE WORK IN THE ROOM

The Debrief Protocol

This protocol is the structure your team uses to translate the diagnostic into priorities. Plan for four hours, ideally split across two two-hour sessions on different days. Designate a facilitator. The facilitator should not be the head of school. The facilitator's role is to hold the structure, slow the conversation when needed, and ask the questions provided in this guide when the room gets stuck.

Ground rules

At the top of the first session, the facilitator reads these aloud. The team agrees to operate by them.

GROUND RULE	WHAT IT MEANS IN PRACTICE
We speak from evidence, not impression	When you make a claim about the school, name the specific example you are basing it on. The facilitator can ask for evidence at any time.
Disagreement is information, not conflict	When team members scored differently, the difference is the most useful place to learn. Move toward it, not around it.
The lowest scorer speaks first	On any question with a wide spread, the team member with the lowest score speaks first and is heard fully before others respond.
The head of school speaks last when others have a closer view	On questions where staff of color, junior staff, or staff in lower-paid roles have closer access to the answer, the head of school waits to speak last.

GROUND RULE	WHAT IT MEANS IN PRACTICE
We name what we see, not what we wish we saw	Aspiration is not data. The diagnostic is asking what is true now, not what is possible if conditions changed.
We do not move the conversation to other schools	Comparison to worse examples elsewhere is a deflection. Bring the conversation back to your school.
We do not move the conversation to future plans	Future plans are not present practice. The diagnostic is asking what is true now, not what is intended.

Round one. Domain by domain (two hours)

For each of the four domains, work through this sequence. Plan for thirty minutes per domain.

The facilitator names the domain average and the spread. The facilitator names the two or three questions where the spread was widest or the average was lowest. The team member with the lowest score on the question with the widest spread speaks first about what they were seeing and reads relevant evidence from their notes. Other team members respond in order of lowest to highest score, sharing what they were seeing.

QUESTIONS THE FACILITATOR CAN USE TO KEEP THE CONVERSATION HONEST

What evidence were you basing your score on. What would have to be true for this to be a four. What is the cost to the school of this not being a four. Who would tell us a different story than the one we are telling each other right now. If a parent of color or a teacher of color were sitting at this table, what would they want us to look at more closely.

Round two. Synthesis (forty-five minutes)

After all four domains, the team works through three synthesis questions together. These statements become the spine of your priority list. Write them on a board or shared document where the whole team can see them.

SYNTHESIS QUESTION	WHAT YOU ARE LOOKING FOR
Where is our school strongest, and what is producing that strength?	Name a specific practice, structure, or person. Resist the urge to claim strength in every domain. Pick one or two real ones.
Where is our school most vulnerable, and what is the cost of leaving it another year?	Name the vulnerability in plain language. Then name what it costs the school to keep ignoring it. The cost is usually counted in children, families, or staff who have already been or will be harmed.
Where is our leadership team most misaligned about reality, and what does that misalignment make hard for us to do?	Name the misalignment directly. The misalignment itself is often the most important finding of the audit because it explains why the school cannot do certain kinds of work no matter how much it wants to.

Round three. Priorities (forty-five minutes)

Begin with one question. Of everything we surfaced, what is the one thing this school cannot afford to leave another year unaddressed. Let the room sit with the question. Do not rush to fill the silence. The first answer is rarely the deepest answer, and the room often needs three or four minutes of quiet before someone names what most of the team already knew.

From there, work toward two more candidates for the immediate priority list, three or four candidates for near-term work over the next six to twelve months, and three or four candidates for long-term work over the next eighteen months to three years. For each priority, name the owner who is accountable for it, the success indicator the school will use to know whether it has been delivered, and the timeline.

THE TEST OF A REAL PRIORITY

A real priority changes the budget, the calendar, or the org chart. If the priorities your team agrees on do none of those three things, your team has not yet agreed on priorities. You have agreed on language. Slow down and try again.

Round four. Internal versus external (thirty minutes)

Of the priorities your team has named, work through each one and decide together whether it is something your school can resource and lead internally or whether it requires outside support to do honestly. Be precise. The next steps section of this guide will help you make that distinction.

For each priority that requires outside support, decide who is responsible for getting that help and by when. If you defer this decision to email after the session, it usually does not happen.

If the conversation gets stuck

Defensiveness is predictable in this work. It is not a sign that the protocol is failing. It is a sign that the diagnostic is naming something real. If the room defaults to defensiveness, the facilitator returns to ground rule one. Speak from evidence. Ask the speaker what specific example they are basing their statement on.

If the room defaults to comparison with worse examples elsewhere, the facilitator returns to ground rule six and brings the team back to your school, this year, what is true. If the room defaults to future plans, the facilitator returns to ground rule seven and asks what is happening now, not what is intended for later.

If a team member of color or a junior staff member goes quiet mid-conversation, the facilitator pauses and asks them privately, in a break or by note, what would be useful. Do not call them out in front of the room. Their quietness is often information that the conversation has organized around something they cannot keep naming alone.

AFTER THE AUDIT

Next Steps

Most schools that complete this audit honestly will leave with a priority list that mixes work the school can carry internally and work that benefits from outside support. Both kinds of work are real and necessary. This section helps you sort them.

What schools can typically address internally

These are categories of work that most school leadership teams are well positioned to lead on their own once the diagnostic has surfaced what needs to change.

WORKSTREAM	WHAT INTERNAL-LED WORK LOOKS LIKE IN THIS AREA
Compensation review and adjustment	Pull the salary data, do the math, decide what the school can afford to fix and on what timeline. The math itself does not require a consultant.
Curriculum and prepared environment audit	Walk every classroom. Catalogue what is on the shelves and walls. Decide what is missing and order what is needed. Most schools can do this work in a quarter.
Family communication and language access	Audit which families speak which languages and which school communications they receive. Translate the most important communications. Establish a translation budget line.

WORKSTREAM	WHAT INTERNAL-LED WORK LOOKS LIKE IN THIS AREA
Faculty meeting structure and adult learning calendar	Redesign your faculty meetings to redistribute who speaks. Build an adult learning calendar that addresses what surfaced. Most schools have the in-house expertise to plan this.
Discipline data collection and disaggregation	Build a tracking system. Log every redirection, removal, and outside referral by child and category. Review monthly. The data collection itself does not require outside expertise.

What typically requires outside support

These are categories of work where most schools struggle to make meaningful progress without an outside partner. The reasons vary. Some require expertise the school does not yet hold. Some require the kind of accountability that comes from having someone outside the system asking hard questions on a recurring schedule. Some require facilitation through conflict that an internal facilitator cannot hold without becoming a target of the conflict.

WORKSTREAM	WHY OUTSIDE SUPPORT TYPICALLY HELPS
Hiring redesign and pipeline development	Most schools default to the same hiring patterns that produced the current team. Outside support brings new networks, structural redesign of the rubric, and accountability for actually using both.
Board composition and governance work	Boards rarely change their composition through self-reflection. An outside partner working directly with the board chair on succession, recruitment, and orientation makes the work more likely to happen.

WORKSTREAM	WHY OUTSIDE SUPPORT TYPICALLY HELPS
Adult culture conflict and repair	When adult conflict is unresolved or actively harmful, internal facilitation often becomes part of the conflict. An outside facilitator can hold the room without being read as taking sides.
Strategic plan rewrite with equity at the center	Equity-centered strategic planning requires both Montessori expertise and equity expertise applied together. Few internal teams have both deeply enough to lead the work alone.
Sustained accountability across multiple years	Most equity work that lasts is held by a sustained outside partnership over multiple years. Schools that do this work alone tend to lose momentum within eighteen months.
Crisis response when racial harm has occurred	When a racial incident has occurred, the leadership team needs outside facilitation to hold the staff and family conversations that follow. Internal facilitation in crisis tends to compound the harm.

If your school needs outside support

Montessori Makers Group offers Advisory engagement for schools that need sustained outside partnership on the work this audit surfaces. Advisory engagement begins with a consultant-led version of this same audit, in which Hannah Richardson or an MMG-trained consultant facilitates the diagnostic and produces the written Findings and Recommendations document for the leadership team. Most schools that begin with the consultant-led audit move into ongoing Advisory engagement after the closing call.

If you completed this Toolbox Edition first and decided that you need outside support to take the next step, the natural pathway is to bring MMG in for the work that requires it. The diagnostic clarity your team has already produced is the most valuable input to a meaningful Advisory engagement, because the team has already done the looking. We are picking up where you left off.

REACH OUT WHEN YOU ARE READY

Email hannah@montessorimakersgroup.com with the priorities your team identified and a note about what you would like outside support to address. We will schedule a thirty-minute call to talk through scope and fit. Advisory engagement is not the right next step for every school, and we will tell you honestly if it is not the right step for yours.

A closing note

Most schools that complete this audit honestly will find that the leadership team can name the work in front of them more clearly than they could before. That clarity is the point. What you do with it from here is the rest of the work.

If your team did this honestly, you have already done something most schools never do. You looked at your own school, named what is true, and decided what to act on. That is the foundation of equity work. Everything else builds on it.

Montessori Makers Group

Equity-centered Montessori practice for schools, leaders, and the children they serve

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